Expanded Bridges — Next Three

If you hear this · Distrust, “all corrupt,” and “I don’t like Trump / the GOP”

The six steps: Friendly opener · Ask an open question · Listen and acknowledge · **Bridge** · Soft close · Thank them. Use the short bridge in step 4, after you’ve listened and acknowledged.

IF YOU HEAR THIS

“I don’t trust either side.”

Short Bridge

Use this after you’ve listened and let them know you heard them. It’s one or two sentences that move the talk from the national noise to something local they care about, and it ends with a question so they keep talking. If they open up, keep listening. If not, thank them and move on.

“I hear the distrust. On the things that protect your family locally—costs, safety, schools—which still matters most to you?”

The Issue and Expanded Bridge

The facts behind the issue and a longer bridge, for when they want to keep talking.

The issue

Distrust of both parties is common among independents and disengaged Republicans. It usually comes from years of national promises that did not match results, or from the sense that both sides prioritize messaging over delivery.

Short background

Trust is rebuilt more easily on local, concrete issues than on national identity. Costs, neighborhood safety, water with growth, school options, and infrastructure are problems residents experience directly. Local decisions on those issues are still made by people who show up. Starting with the person’s own concern rather than a party label reduces the defensive reaction.

The bridge

“Trust is earned. That’s why I start with what’s hitting your family, not a party speech. What’s the biggest thing affecting you and your family right now — costs, safety, water, schools?” Listen, mirror, and connect to one practical local step.
Ownership close when ready: “We are the they. What’s the one block or one person you’ll cover?”

Deeper Background

For your own preparation. You don’t need to recite this. It helps you understand why people feel this way and answer questions with confidence.

Why distrust is widespread

National polarization and repeated cycles of high rhetoric followed by limited delivery have eroded trust across the spectrum. Many voters no longer grant either party the benefit of the doubt. The emotional starting point is

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skepticism, not curiosity.

Supporting context

- Local issues (costs, housing, water constraints with growth, public safety, school quality) are experienced directly and can be discussed without requiring party identification.
- Trust is more readily rebuilt through consistent local follow-through than through national messaging.
- Neighbor-to-neighbor conversations that begin with the other person's stated concern lower defensiveness and create space for a practical next step.
- In Yavapai County, growth-related pressures on water, housing, and infrastructure remain frequent resident concerns that are decided at the local level.

The perspective shift

Distrust does not have to be resolved before action. The useful shift is from "I don't trust them" to "I can still influence the one local result that affects my family." Starting with the person's own concern earns the right to continue the conversation. No party loyalty is required. Trust is earned one conversation at a time.

Ownership close

"We are the they. What's the one thing you'll own?"

2-Minute Two-Person Conversation

A sample conversation from start to finish. Practice it with a partner until it sounds like you.

Setting: Front porch or sidewalk. Neighbor has just said they don't trust either side.

Neighbor: Honestly, I don't trust either side.
You: I hear you. A lot of people have been disappointed before.
Neighbor: They all promise and nothing happens.
You: Trust is earned. That's why I start with what's hitting your family, not a party speech. What's the biggest thing affecting you and your family right now — costs, safety, water, schools?
Neighbor: Costs. And the water, with all the building going on.
You: Those get decided locally, by the people who show up. You don't have to trust anybody to have a say in that. Would you be open to one practical step — checking your registration, or talking with one neighbor about the water?
Neighbor: Maybe. I could check my registration.
You: That's great. I'll follow up next week. We are the they.

Video script (one speaker, about 2 minutes)

When someone says, "I don't trust either side," they're usually telling you they've been disappointed before.
The bridge we use is simple: "Trust is earned. That's why I start with what's hitting your family, not a party speech."
Then we ask what's affecting them most right now — costs, safety, water with the growth, schools. We listen. We mirror. We connect it to one practical local step they can take.
That's how trust starts to rebuild: not with a speech, but with a neighbor conversation about a real local issue and one thing they can do about it.
Neighbors talking to neighbors. We are the they.

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IF YOU HEAR THIS

“They’re all corrupt / nothing changes.”

Short Bridge

Use this after you’ve listened and let them know you heard them. It’s one or two sentences that move the talk from the national noise to something local they care about, and it ends with a question so they keep talking. If they open up, keep listening. If not, thank them and move on.

“A lot of people feel that way. Local turnout still decides school boards, city, and county outcomes. What’s one result that would matter to your family?”

The Issue and Expanded Bridge

The facts behind the issue and a longer bridge, for when they want to keep talking.

The issue

The belief that “they’re all corrupt” or “nothing ever changes” is a common expression of frustration. It often mixes real examples of misconduct with a broader sense that participation is pointless.

Short background

Some skepticism is justified. At the same time, local offices and local races are decided by turnout. When fewer people participate, the same small groups continue to set policy on taxes, growth, water, safety, and schools. Local results can and do change when neighbors organize around concrete issues.

The bridge

“Some of that feeling is fair. Local turnout still decides who we get. On the issue that matters most to your family right now, would you be open to one practical step so the people who show up include you?” Listen, mirror, and close on a single commitment.
Ownership close: “We are the they. What’s the one block or one person you’ll cover?”

Deeper Background

For your own preparation. You don’t need to recite this. It helps you understand why people feel this way and answer questions with confidence.

Why the claim resonates

High-profile national and state examples of misconduct or unfulfilled promises reinforce the sense that systems are rigged or inert. The generalization (“they’re all the same / nothing changes”) becomes a protective stance that reduces the emotional cost of disengagement.

Supporting context

- Local elections in Yavapai County (school boards, municipal races, bonds, county offices) draw fewer voters than presidential races, and some are decided by a few hundred votes.
- Policy on growth management, water, public safety, and local taxes is set by the officials who win those races.
- Organized neighbor-level participation (registration, one block covered, PC interest) adds voters where margins are smallest, which is where one person’s effort counts most.
- Acknowledging that some skepticism is fair lowers defensiveness and opens the door to a practical local discussion.

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The perspective shift

The useful shift is from “nothing changes so I won’t participate” to “local turnout still decides who sets the rules on the issue I care about.” Corruption or inertia at higher levels does not erase the effect of local participation. The person does not need to trust the system wholesale; they only need to influence one local result. “We are the they” is the ownership response to the claim that nothing changes.

Ownership close

“We are the they. What’s the one thing you’ll own?”

2-Minute Two-Person Conversation

A sample conversation from start to finish. Practice it with a partner until it sounds like you.

Setting: Front porch or sidewalk. Neighbor has just said they’re all corrupt and nothing changes.

Neighbor: They’re all corrupt. Nothing ever changes.
You: Some of that feeling is fair. We’ve all seen examples that justify the frustration.
Neighbor: So why bother?
You: Local turnout still decides who we get. The people who show up still decide taxes, growth, water, safety, and schools. Which of those is hitting your family most?
Neighbor: Taxes, for sure. And the growth.
You: That’s decided right here. On that issue, would you be open to one practical step so the people who show up include you — checking your registration, or talking with one neighbor?
Neighbor: I guess I could talk to my neighbor.
You: That’s great. I’ll follow up next week. We are the they.

Video script (one speaker, about 2 minutes)

When someone says, “They’re all corrupt — nothing ever changes,” part of that feeling is fair. We’ve all seen examples that justify the frustration.
The bridge is straightforward: “Some of that feeling is fair. Local turnout still decides who we get.”
Then we bring it local. The people who show up still decide taxes, growth, water, safety, and schools. We ask which of those is hitting their family most, we listen, and we offer one practical step so the people who show up include them.
That’s the shift: from “nothing changes” to “local turnout still decides this, and I can be part of who shows up.”
Neighbors talking to neighbors. We are the they.

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IF YOU HEAR THIS

“I don’t like Trump / I don’t like the GOP.”

Short Bridge

Use this after you’ve listened and let them know you heard them. It’s one or two sentences that move the talk from the national noise to something local they care about, and it ends with a question so they keep talking. If they open up, keep listening. If not, thank them and move on.

“Fair enough. This conversation is about local results that affect your family, not national personalities. Which local issue is weighing on you most?”

The Issue and Expanded Bridge

The facts behind the issue and a longer bridge, for when they want to keep talking.

The issue

Personal dislike of a national figure or of the party brand is a frequent reason independents and disengaged Republicans give for disengaging. The objection is often about identity or tone rather than about specific local results.

Short background

The Grassroots Conversations model deliberately does not lead with national framing. The goal is trust plus a practical next step on an issue the person already cares about. Costs, neighborhood safety, water with growth, housing, and school options can be discussed without requiring affection for any national figure or party label.

The bridge

“You don’t have to like anyone to care about costs, safety, and schools. Which of those is weighing on you and your family most right now?” Listen, mirror, and offer one local next step. Keep party language out unless they raise it.
Ownership close: “We are the they. What’s the one block or one person you’ll cover?”

Deeper Background

For your own preparation. You don’t need to recite this. It helps you understand why people feel this way and answer questions with confidence.

Why the objection appears

National figures and party brands dominate media. For many voters the brand has become a reason to opt out even when they still care about local results. The objection is real as an emotional barrier; it does not have to be the end of a useful conversation.

Supporting context

- Our training asks volunteers not to lead with national Trump framing unless the other person raises it.
- Kitchen-table issues (costs, safety, schools, water, housing) remain the highest-yield topics with reachable independents and disengaged Republicans.
- Local races and local policy on those issues do not require the voter to endorse any national figure.
- In mixed or civic settings the materials already keep language nonpartisan; party connection, if any, happens only in private follow-up.

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The perspective shift

The person does not need to like a national figure or the party brand to care about a local result and take one practical step. The conversation stays on the issue they name. Affiliation can be discussed later if they choose; it is not a prerequisite for the next step.

Ownership close

“We are the they. What’s the one thing you’ll own?”

2-Minute Two-Person Conversation

A sample conversation from start to finish. Practice it with a partner until it sounds like you.

Setting: Front porch or sidewalk. Neighbor has just said they don’t like Trump or the GOP.

Neighbor: I’ll be honest, I don’t like Trump. I don’t like the GOP.
You: That’s fair. A lot of people feel that way, and I appreciate you being straight with me.
Neighbor: So I’m not really interested.
You: You don’t have to like anyone to care about costs, safety, and schools. Which of those is weighing on you and your family most right now?
Neighbor: Schools. My kids are in school here.
You: That gets decided locally, by the school board and the people who vote in those races. Would you be open to one practical step — checking your registration, or talking with one other parent about it?
Neighbor: I could check my registration.
You: That’s great. Thanks for talking with me. We are the they.

Video script (one speaker, about 2 minutes)

Sometimes you’ll hear, “I don’t like Trump,” or “I don’t like the GOP.” That’s common, and it’s often about national tone more than local results.
The bridge is direct: “You don’t have to like anyone to care about costs, safety, and schools.”
Then we ask which of those is weighing on them most. We listen. We mirror. We offer one practical local step.
We do not lead with national framing unless they bring it up.
That’s the shift: from brand dislike to a concrete local concern and one thing they can do about it.
Neighbors talking to neighbors. We are the they.

Neighbors talking to neighbors. We are the they.

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